

LSO 100- The Canadian Short Story

Week 7 — Indigenous Voices and Storytelling

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Storytelling as Knowledge, Resistance, and Memory

This week, we turn our attention to **Indigenous voices and storytelling** in Canadian literature through two powerful contemporary short stories: "**Borders**" by Thomas King and "**Traplines**" by Eden Robinson. Both works engage questions of identity, belonging, family, trauma, survival, and cultural continuity.

Crucially, storytelling in these texts is not merely a narrative device. It functions as a means of **preserving knowledge, expressing resistance, maintaining cultural memory, and connecting generations**. As we read, we must approach these works as carefully crafted literary achievements – not only as social commentary.



A Note on Reading Indigenous Literature

Avoid Reduction

Indigenous literature must never be reduced to a single experience or perspective. Writers come from different nations, histories, and cultural traditions with distinct worldviews.

Read Literarily

These stories are shaped by voice, symbolism, narration, tone, characterization, imagery, and structure – read them as crafted works, not only as social documents.

Think About Power

Both stories ask how identity and power operate not only politically, but *emotionally and psychologically* – through ordinary human experience and everyday moments.

WEEK 7 · AT A GLANCE

Two Stories, Shared Terrain



"Borders" — Thomas King (1993)

A Blackfoot mother and her son attempt to cross the Canada–US border to visit family. What unfolds is a profound meditation on identity, sovereignty, and the limits of colonial categories.



"Traplines" — Eden Robinson (1996)

A teenage narrator navigates family dysfunction, violence, and the weight of silence in a contemporary Indigenous community, rendered with devastating restraint and emotional precision.

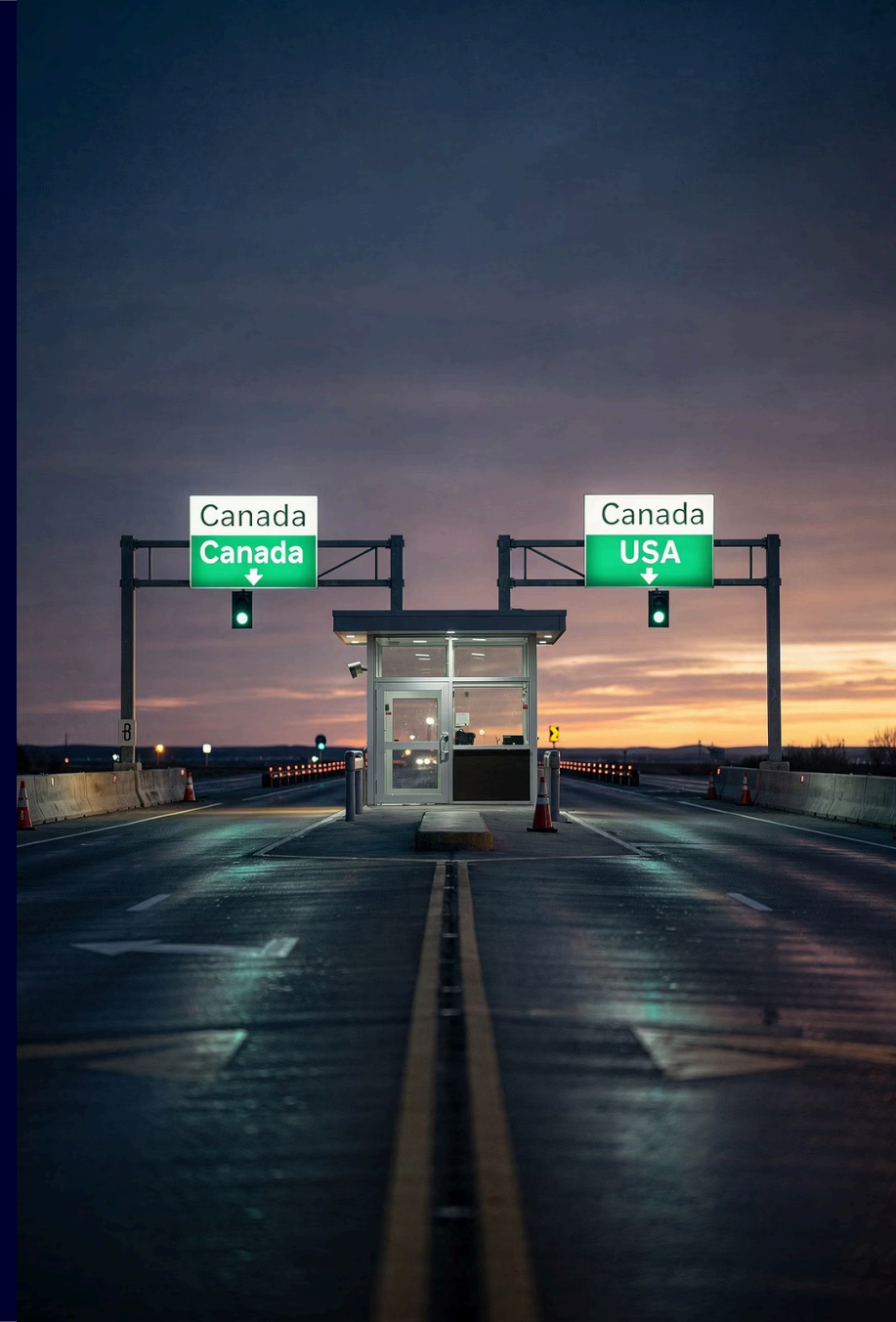
"BORDERS" · THOMAS KING

Identity Beyond Colonial Categories

On the surface, "Borders" tells a simple story: a mother and son attempt to cross the border to visit family in Salt Lake City. But the story pivots entirely on a single repeated exchange. When border guards ask the mother to declare her citizenship, she answers:

"**Blackfoot.**" — King, 1993

This moment becomes the emotional and intellectual centre of the story. The political border separating Canada and the United States was **imposed long after Indigenous nations already existed on the land**. To identify as "Canadian" or "American" would mean accepting categories created by colonial governments — not by her own people or history.



Who Has the Authority to Define Identity?

The System's Failure

The border guards cannot understand the mother's answer because the institutional system only recognizes state-sanctioned categories: passports, legal definitions, national citizenship. It is **incapable of imagining identity outside these structures**.

The Mother's Resistance

Notably, the mother never becomes emotional or dramatic. Her resistance is **calm, patient, and consistent**. King suggests that *dignity itself can be a form of resistance*. Her refusal alone exposes the weakness of the system surrounding her – no speeches required.

King transforms an ordinary bureaucratic situation into a larger philosophical and political question about authority, sovereignty, and self-determination. The story exposes the limits of institutional thinking without ever raising its voice.

"Borders" as Symbolic Structure

The title operates on multiple levels simultaneously. King invites readers to think beyond the physical checkpoint toward deeper, symbolic borders that structure colonial relationships.



Cultural Borders

Between Indigenous and colonial worldviews



Identity Borders

Between legal identity and lived identity



Inclusion / Exclusion

Who is granted belonging, and by whose authority?



Visibility Borders

Between being recognized and being made invisible

The border station itself becomes a symbol of institutional authority and surveillance – a mechanism for organizing human identity into fixed categories that the mother's presence fundamentally unsettles.

Storytelling Among the Stars

Near the story's end, stranded between borders and unable to enter either country, the mother and son spend the night outside the checkpoint. During this liminal time, the mother tells stories connected to **stars and constellations**.

Cultural Survival

Oral stories preserve knowledge that political systems cannot erase or confiscate.

Resistance Against Erasure

The stories of the stars exist beyond the authority of governments or border checkpoints entirely.

Intergenerational Connection

Knowledge is transmitted relationally – through memory, voice, listening, and shared experience.

While political systems attempt to control movement and identity, storytelling reconnects the characters to something **older and more enduring than the border itself**.



Humor, Irony, and the Reversal of Power



Why Humor Matters Here

Although "Borders" addresses serious themes, King uses **subtle but strategic humor and irony** throughout. The narrator describes border guards in slightly exaggerated ways – comparing their uniforms and seriousness to figures from old Western films.

This irony **reverses traditional power relationships**. Rather than Indigenous characters appearing "out of place," the border system itself begins to look strange and irrational.

Humor also prevents the story from becoming didactic. King trusts irony and narrative perspective to expose contradictions naturally, rather than telling readers what to think directly.

The Child Narrator and Perspective

1

Observational Calm

The son narrates with a deceptively simple voice — calm and curious, unaware of the full political weight of events he describes.

2

Dramatic Irony

Readers interpret political and emotional significance even when the narrator describes events casually. The gap between what he sees and what we understand creates powerful irony.

3

Learning by Witnessing

The son learns identity not through formal instruction but through watching his mother's dignity, patience, and persistence across every exchange.

The choice of a child narrator emphasizes the story's central concern with **transmission** — how knowledge, identity, and cultural values pass between generations through lived example rather than formal teaching.

"TRAPLINES" · EDEN ROBINSON

Family, Violence, and Emotional Survival

Where "Borders" focuses on nationhood and institutional identity, "Traplines" enters the intimate and often dangerous terrain of **family relationships, trauma, and survival** within contemporary Indigenous life.

The story follows **Will**, a teenage narrator who gradually becomes aware of the abuse taking place within his cousin Tom's home. Robinson's greatest strength is **restraint**: she never explains everything openly. Meaning is assembled through gestures, silences, fragmented dialogue, and the atmosphere of spaces — mirroring how trauma itself is often experienced indirectly.

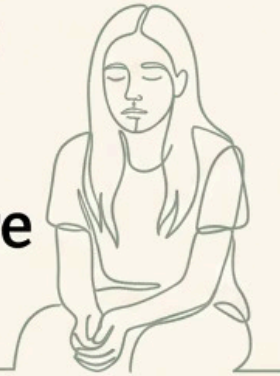


The Art of Restraint: Robinson's Narrative Technique



GESTURES:
Physical moves
signal emotion.

SILENCE:
Unsaid
words
carry more
weight.



more weight.



WITHDRAWAL:
Pulling back when
threatened.



DIALOGUE:
Incomplete
exchanges
imply fear.



ATMOSPHERE:
Settings reflect
psychological state.

**BODY
LANGUAGE:**
Physical
responses
reveal the
unspeakable.



This technique reflects the reality of trauma itself. Trauma is rarely experienced as a clean, fully articulated event. It surfaces through tension, fear, and instability — and Robinson's prose mirrors this truthfully rather than imposing false clarity.

Silence as a Structural Force

What Silence Does in the Story

Characters in "Traplines" consistently **avoid direct discussion** of violence or emotional pain. This silence is not absence — it is its own kind of language, charged with meaning and danger that readers must actively interpret.

Silence as Survival

- Protection from further harm
- Expression of fear and learned helplessness
- Emotional exhaustion under sustained stress
- Inherited behavior across generations
- Isolation within one's own experience

The emotional power of "Traplines" comes substantially from **what remains unsaid**. Readers must interpret pauses, reactions, and absences as carefully as spoken dialogue — making the reading experience psychologically immersive and unsettling.

The Symbolic Weight of "Traplines"



Beyond the Literal Meaning

Traditionally, traplines are routes used for trapping animals. Robinson expands this into a powerful symbolic framework that operates across the story's emotional landscape:

- **Cycles of violence** that repeat across generations
- **Emotional entrapment** within abusive family structures
- **Inherited trauma** passed down without language or acknowledgement
- **Limited pathways** for escape or meaningful change

Crucially, the title does not render characters as helpless victims. Robinson's people continue searching for **connection, care, and survival** despite fear and instability.

Setting, Atmosphere, and Psychological Space



Domestic Instability

Domestic spaces in Robinson's story feel tense and unpredictable. The home – traditionally a site of safety – becomes a space of danger and unease.



Atmosphere as Meaning

Physical environments mirror psychological states. Tone, pacing, and sensory detail carry emotional meaning that direct narration does not provide.



Implied Danger

In Robinson's world, danger is rarely announced directly. It is implied through texture, hesitation, and the weight of things left unspoken between characters.

This is one reason "Traplines" feels so emotionally intense. Robinson constructs an atmosphere where **readers feel the threat before it is named** – a deeply immersive and psychologically honest technique.

Narrative Voice: Comparing King and Robinson

"Borders" — Observational Distance

The child narrator in King's story creates **irony and distance**. His calm, deceptively simple voice allows readers to see political significance he himself does not fully grasp. The narrative gap generates meaning.

"Traplines" — Emotional Intimacy

Will's narration creates **closeness and instability**. Readers experience confusion, fear, loyalty, and uncertainty from inside his perspective. The voice feels immediate, raw, and resistant to easy resolution.

Both authors use first-person narration to serve very different emotional purposes. This demonstrates how **narrative voice is itself a deliberate literary choice** — not merely a vehicle for plot, but a shaping force that determines what readers know, feel, and understand.

Robinson's Refusal of Easy Closure

"Trauma itself rarely resolves neatly – and Robinson's story refuses to pretend otherwise."

"Traplines" does not move toward tidy resolution or moral conclusion. Will does not rescue Tom. The violence is not stopped by a moment of dramatic intervention. Readers are left holding **unresolved tension, ambiguity, and discomfort**.

This refusal of simple closure is one of Robinson's most important literary choices. She resists the impulse to reduce pain into a lesson, or to offer the reader the comfort of understanding fully what her characters cannot understand themselves.

The story asks readers to **sit with complexity** rather than reach for simplistic resolution – an honest representation of how trauma, family violence, and survival actually function.



Indigenous Storytelling and the Canadian Short Story

Together, "Borders" and "Traplines" expand and reshape the Canadian short story tradition by **centering Indigenous voices, perspectives, and storytelling forms**.

01

Center Indigenous Voices

Both stories foreground Indigenous perspectives without explaining them away or reducing them to symbols for non-Indigenous audiences.

02

Challenge Simplified Narratives

King and Robinson resist national myths and stereotypes, insisting on the full complexity of lived Indigenous experience.

03

Connect Storytelling to Memory

Both works demonstrate how narrative form itself carries cultural continuity, transmitting identity and knowledge across generations.

04

Reveal Systems Through Lives

Large systems – borders, institutions, family violence, colonial history – become visible through intimate, ordinary human experience.



Conclusion: Listening Carefully

"Borders" — Thomas King

Explores **identity, nationhood, and resistance** through a seemingly ordinary border-crossing. Calm repetition, irony, and starlight storytelling transform a bureaucratic moment into a philosophical statement about sovereignty and cultural continuity.

"Traplines" — Eden Robinson

Examines **family relationships, silence, vulnerability, and survival** through emotionally intimate narration. Restraint, atmosphere, and the weight of what remains unsaid create a story of devastating psychological realism.

- 📌 As you move through this week's readings, pay close attention not only to **what happens** in the stories — but also to **how the stories are told**. Voice, form, and structure are not decorative. They are meaning.

References

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